

Conversations
Centre for Positive Mental Health and Well-being
Azim Premji University

Guidelines for Counselling Services
(For Parents of Students Below 18 Years)

Conversations at Azim Premji University is a centre for positive mental health and well-being of the students, faculty and staff of the University. Our aim is to support our community through various mental health services. The counsellors at the centre are professionally trained and provide empathetic emotional support and create a safe space for sharing concerns. However, our support is not a substitute for psychiatric interventions or institutional help.

As a student at Azim Premji University, your child has access to counselling at Conversations. Parental consent is necessary for them to receive counselling because they are under 18 years of age. The purpose of this form is to inform you about the counselling process and your child's rights and responsibilities as a client.

Please read the following points carefully and Sign the Undertaking and Consent Form

Counselling process

- Your child can initiate the process by contacting the University Counselling Centre to schedule an appointment. Before the first session, they will be required to fill out a form to help the counsellor understand their background and concerns.
- Sessions will be conducted by a qualified mental health professional.
- The counselling process could help one in becoming more self-aware, feel more empowered, enjoy better interpersonal relationships and reduce stress. The process typically includes discussions on one's personal challenges and difficulties
- Each session will last approximately 45–50 minutes. The frequency and number of sessions will be mutually decided by the counsellor and your child based on child's needs.
- Your child is expected to arrive on time and cancel appointments at least 24 hours in advance if needed.

Confidentiality:

As a client, your child has the right to confidentiality. Any information that your child shares with their counsellor will be held private and no one will have access to it, except the counselling team, if necessary. If needed, your child's counsellor may collaborate with other healthcare providers (e.g. physician, psychiatrist etc.) to coordinate care.

Exceptions to Confidentiality include:

- **Risk of self-harm, suicide, or causing harm to others:** As part of the university protocol, the counsellor must share this information to the University's Risk Team. This is to ensure timely emergency response. Your child's counsellor may contact the emergency contact person listed, family members or anyone in a position to prevent the potential harm, revealing only necessary information.
- **Incidents of sexual harassment:** In case of any incident involving sexual harassment, the information will be disclosed to the University's Internal Committee under the POSH (Prevention of Sexual Harassment) guidelines, as required by law.
- **Substance use/storage/peddling:** The University has a zero-tolerance policy towards substance usage/storage/peddling within the campus and the university hostels. If any information about this comes up in your child's sessions, their counsellor, after keeping your child informed, is bound to inform the relevant official in the University.

Medications:

- Counsellors do not prescribe medications. However, in the counseling process, if the counsellor recommends seeing a psychiatrist for evaluation and there is a need for medication to support therapy, we will contact you and update you regarding your child's needs.

Disclaimer: Please note parental consent is required and applicable only for those students who are below the age of 18 at the time they reach out for counselling. Once your child turns 18, we will take informed consent from them directly to continue the counselling process with them as legal adults.

For any questions/clarifications regarding this form, write to conversations@apu.edu.in and a member of our team will address your questions and concerns.

After reading this guideline, you are required to sign the **UNDERTAKING AND CONSENT FORM**